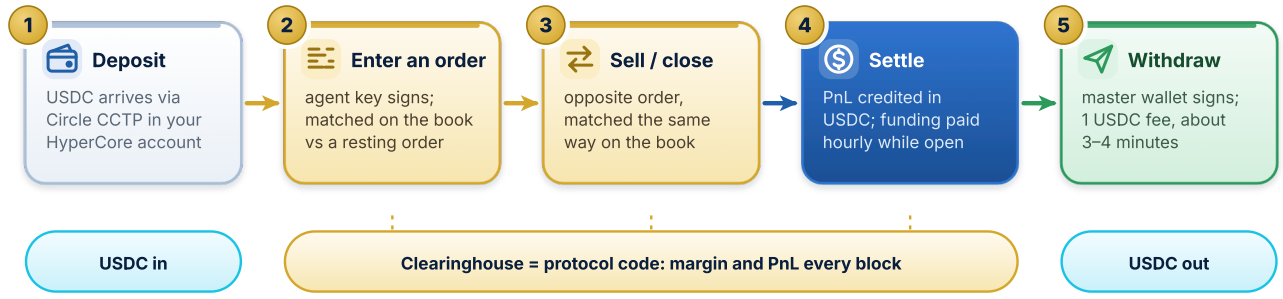
HYPERLIQUID 101 · ONE TRADE

The life of one trade, start to finish

Five steps: put USDC in, open a position, close it, get paid, take USDC out. Everything in between happens on Hyperliquid's own blockchain, where the order book and the margin system are built into the chain itself.



The journey. Steps 2–4 run inside the HyperCore clearinghouse; steps 1 and 5 move USDC on and off the platform.

1 Deposit USDC IN

You fund the account with USDC, the collateral for all trading. The current route is **native USDC through Circle's cross-chain transfer system (CCTP)**: USDC sent from Arbitrum, Ethereum, Base and other supported chains arrives as USDC in your HyperCore perp account.

The older Arbitrum bridge still works but is now legacy (minimum 5 USDC). Once funded, one free "Enable Trading" signature creates an **agent key** that can trade but cannot withdraw.

2 Enter an order: who takes the other side? HYPERCORE

Your agent key signs the order (for example, buy 1 BTC-PERP, limit) and sends it to the validators. Every validator runs the same matching engine, and the order is matched on a public order book by price, then time.

Resting makers
Market makers and other traders who left limit orders on the book.

The HLP vault
A community vault that quotes both sides of the book, like any other market maker.

Other traders
Anyone whose order crosses yours, from a person on the website to a trading bot.

Your counterparty is another account on the book. The clearinghouse is protocol code: it checks margin and books PnL every block, but it does not take the other side of your trade. If a losing account cannot pay, its position is liquidated on the book. If that fails, the HLP vault takes over the position, and auto-deleveraging is the last resort.

3 Sell / close HYPERCORE

To exit, you place the opposite order: sell to close a long, or buy to close a short. It can be a market or limit order, and you can close all or part of the position. It is matched exactly like step 2, against whoever is resting on the other side at that moment.

4 Settle USDC

When the position closes, **realized PnL is credited instantly in USDC** to your perp balance, less trading fees. At the base perps tier these are 0.045% for takers and 0.015% for makers, falling with volume.

While the position was open, **funding was exchanged every hour** directly between longs and shorts. When the perp trades above the external oracle price, longs pay shorts, and when it trades below, shorts pay longs. Hyperliquid takes no fee on funding.

5 Withdraw USDC OUT

Sign the withdrawal with your **master wallet**, since the agent key cannot withdraw. Hyperliquid debits the amount plus a **flat 1 USDC fee**, validators sign it, and USDC arrives in your Arbitrum wallet in **about 3–4 minutes**. You don't need ETH or HYPE. USDC can also leave through Circle's CCTP to other supported chains.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR CAPITAL MARKETS

Each step settles in minutes on a public ledger. But the counterparty is an anonymous account, the clearinghouse is code rather than a regulated CCP, and the backstop is a voluntary vault rather than a members' default fund. The main controls are how the master (withdrawal) key is held and how much USDC sits on the platform.

Prepared by the Head of Digital Asset Technology, RBC Capital Markets. Sources (retrieved October 28, 2026): Hyperliquid Docs, "USDC" (native USDC; legacy Arbitrum bridge), API "USDC / Legacy Bridge" (5 USDC minimum; withdrawals in 3–4 minutes), "Fees", "Funding", "Liquidations", "Auto-deleveraging", "How to start trading" (hyperliquid.gitbook.io); Circle Developer Docs, "CCTP-enabled HyperCore transfers"; Hyperliquid Wiki and Chainstack (1 USDC withdrawal fee). For internal education only. Not investment advice or an endorsement of any venue.